J&K

HULLABALOO AT HAZRATBAL

A renovation that should have awed the devout ends up creating a blasphemy controversy and bitter politicking

By **Kaleem Geelani**



FAITH MATTERS Devotees at the Hazratbal shrine on Eid, Srinagar, Sept. 6; (inset) the vandalised inauguration plaque

RELIGION AND POLITICS may be like the two sides of a corbelled arch, but Kashmir's Hazratbal is living up to its history as a site where the two often meet to make fire. The white-domed shrine on the banks of Dal Lake, which houses the Prophet's holy relic, has seen renovation before. The most feted one, under Sheikh Abdullah in 1968-79, yielded its present marble avatar. But now, the J&K Waqf Board's year-long revamp has hit the headlines for a different kind of novelty.

Some of it was enchanting fusion: newly painted interiors got custom-made Turkish chandeliers, woven into a native architectural space, whispering cordially with the traditional *khat-amband* ceiling art. But that wasn't the only new entry. Also on a wall was an inauguration plaque, with the Ashokan national emblem engraved on it.

On September 3, an awed public had started streaming in—the first of lakhs of footfalls the storied Islamic shrine registers annually across religions and sects. But the jam-packed September 5 Friday prayer, usually a poignant precursor to the grand Eid-e-Milad event, erupted into a major controversy. The emblem, featuring the Ashokan Lion and Wheel, was defaced with stones amid slogans. The protesters called it an act of blasphemy, since Islam rejects the depiction of any idol.

A FIGURATIVE QUESTION

Backing the protesters was Kashmir's entire native polity. "Government emblems are for government functions. Mosques, dargahs, temples, gurdwaras are not their place," said CM Omar Abdullah, questioning the motives behind the act. The National Conference has long leveraged Hazratbal; Omar is a legatee of that. But this time, he had company. The PDP's Iltija Mufti blamed the Waqf Board for provoking Kashmiris by blaspheming a revered space. Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, the Valley's chief cleric, cited Islamic teachings explicitly prohibiting plaques, emblems, figures or symbols in religious places. Even Peoples Conference chief

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MAHARASHTRA

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By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**